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ON THE EVE of our flight to Geneva, I made an address to the nation in which I said we were at a special moment in history, with a unique opportunity to set the course of peace through the twenty-first century, and I really felt that way. It was my hope and purpose that at Geneva Mikhail Gorbachev and I would begin a process that our successors and the peoples of our countries would continue after we were gone. The American goal at Geneva, I said, was not only to avoid war, but to strengthen peace; not only to prevent confrontation, but to begin the process of removing the sources of tension that produced confrontation; not to paper over our differences, but to acknowledge and address them realistically; to encourage talk not only between our leaders and diplomats, but between the people of our countries: “Since the dawn of the nuclear age, every American president has sought to limit and end the dangerous competition in nuclear arms. I have no higher priority than to finally realize that dream.”

In going to Geneva, I was also planning to live by an old Russian adage:

Dovorey no provorey.

Trust, but verify.

We left Andrews Air Force Base aboard Air Force One shortly after eight o’clock in the morning on November 16, 1985. Just before takeoff, we got word that the Soviets had allowed several of their citizens who were married to Americans to join their spouses in the United States. One wife hadn’t seen her American husband in eleven years. During some of my attempts at quiet diplomacy, I’d suggested we’d look favorably on such a decision to reunify